

Familiar Guest — Business Opportunity Brief

Direct booking, made effortless for everyday rental owners

The Concept

Familiar Guest is the simplest way for individual rental owners to take bookings directly from their own trusted guests — and, when they choose, from the public — without surrendering 15% or more, and the guest relationship, to Airbnb. Owners keep their existing listing exactly as it is, import it in minutes, and begin taking direct bookings under their own name, with payments, rental agreements, and trust safeguards handled automatically.

The product is built around one promise: near-zero effort to set up. We pull the owner's listing and photos from their existing Airbnb listing, sync their Airbnb calendar instantly, and verify their identity once — then they simply share a booking link.

The Opportunity

- The U.S. and Mexico short-term rental market represents roughly \$65-\$70 billion in annual gross booking value.
 - About 25-30% of an active owner's bookings are repeat or referral guests — the type that can move to direct booking — putting realistically direct-bookable volume near \$9-\$13 billion.
 - Airbnb's shift to a host fee of roughly 15.5%, and the fact that its AirCover protection does not apply to off-platform bookings, create both the financial motive to go direct and the trust gap we close.
 - Existing tools (OwnerRez, Lodgify, Hostaway) are built for professional operators. No one cleanly serves the casual owner who simply wants a simple, trustworthy way to take repeat guests direct.
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How It Works — Effortless Onboarding

Our entire go-to-market depends on removing effort. The owner's path to a live direct-booking link has four short steps:

1. **Import in minutes:** pull listing details and photos straight from the owner's existing Airbnb listing — no retyping, no re-uploading.
 2. **Instant calendar sync:** connect the Airbnb calendar via iCal on day one so availability stays current and double-bookings are prevented.
 3. **Verify once:** a short, Stripe-backed identity check (legal name, date of birth, address, last four of SSN, and a payout account) that most owners clear in minutes — presented under Familiar Guest branding.
 4. **Share and book:** the owner sends a branded booking link to their guests; payment, the rental agreement, and the digital house manual are handled automatically.
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Plans We Offer

All owners must pass Stripe identity verification before listing a property or collecting payment — no exceptions. Card processing is passed through to owners at cost on every plan.

Plan	Pricing	Best for
Pay-as-you-go	5% per paid booking + card fees; \$5 per free booking; no monthly fee, cancel anytime	Seasonal or low-volume owners testing direct booking

Solo	\$29/month, 1 property, no commission (card fees passed through at cost)	Active owners above ~\$7K/yr in bookings
Pro	\$59/month, up to 5 properties, no commission	Multi-unit owners above ~\$14K/yr in bookings
Guest Screening	\$5 per booking (our cost + 25%) — optional add-on	ID + fraud check, recommended for public bookings
Protected Booking	\$19.99 per booking (our cost + 25%) — optional add-on	Screening plus damage protection up to \$1M

Trust & Safeguards

Because Familiar Guest processes the payment, we can offer protections a do-it-yourself website cannot:

- **Funds held until check-in (escrow)**, so a misrepresented or fake listing cannot simply take the money and disappear.
- **Verified owners** — every owner is identity-verified through Stripe as a condition of payout.
- **Optional guest screening and damage protection** for owners who open bookings to the public.

Financial Projections (Years 1-3)

Revised June 2026 to reflect solo-founder development model: platform built by the founder using AI-assisted development tools, deployed on Vercel, with a \$5,000 budget for outside contract help on safety-critical components.

Metric	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Active owners (year-end)	600	3,500	12,000
Average active owners	250	2,000	7,500
Revenue	\$87,500	\$700,000	\$2,625,000
Gross profit (78% margin)	\$68,250	\$546,000	\$2,047,500
Operating expenses	\$11,355	\$15,655	\$47,755
Operating profit / (loss)	\$56,895	\$530,345	\$1,999,745
Operating margin	65%	76%	76%

Operating expense detail

Category	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Infrastructure (Vercel, Supabase, domain)	\$555	\$855	\$2,415
SaaS & services (Resend, DocuSeal, monitoring)	\$360	\$1,260	\$2,700
AI & dev tools (Claude, Cursor)	\$1,440	\$1,440	\$1,440
Outside help & professional (contract dev, legal, insurance, accounting)	\$8,500	\$6,500	\$11,000

Marketing & acquisition	\$500	\$5,000	\$14,000
Customer support (tooling + part-time contractor in Y3)	\$0	\$600	\$16,200
Total	\$11,355	\$15,655	\$47,755

Key assumptions

- Blended revenue per active owner of approximately \$350 per year, reflecting a mix weighted toward the no-commitment 5% plan and the \$29 Solo plan.
- Gross margin of approximately 78%, after Stripe Connect platform fees, hosting, and third-party APIs (calendar sync, screening administration). Card processing is passed through to owners at cost.
- Growth driven primarily by low-friction onboarding and guest-and-owner referrals rather than paid acquisition; modest paid marketing is included in operating expenses.
- Revenue is calculated on the average number of active owners during each year to reflect the ramp in adoption.
- **Development model:** solo founder with professional developer and product management experience, building with AI-assisted tools (Claude Code, Cursor). \$5,000 budgeted for contract review of safety-critical components (Stripe webhooks, escrow logic, security hardening). No full-time hires until unit economics justify it.
- **First headcount (Year 3):** part-time customer support contractor (~10 hrs/wk) as owner base crosses ~5,000.

These figures are illustrative projections based on the assumptions above, not guarantees. Results depend heavily on owner acquisition and retention.

Funding Need

Under the solo-founder model, the business is **profitable from Year 1** with no external funding required. Total operating expenses across all three years sum to approximately \$75,000 — well within reach of personal savings or a small friends-and-family round. The original projection of a \$750K-\$1M seed raise assumed hiring a development team; this is no longer necessary given AI-assisted development and the founder's technical background.

If external capital is pursued, it would be for **growth acceleration** (marketing, partnerships, or strategic hires), not survival.

Risks & Honest Notes

- **Adoption inertia:** repeat guests may rebook on Airbnb out of habit. Converting them to direct booking is the central assumption of the model.
 - **Calendar dependence:** instant setup relies on Airbnb's iCal feed, which Airbnb controls and could restrict.
 - **Public-booking trust:** scaling beyond trusted guests requires the escrow, verification, and screening stack to be airtight first.
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Recommended Next Steps

1. **Validate with 30-50 target owners:** confirm the share of bookings that are repeat guests and their willingness to take them direct.
2. **Build the core:** Airbnb listing and photo import, instant iCal sync, Stripe-verified onboarding, a branded booking link, and payments with escrow.
3. **Launch trusted-guest mode** in one beachhead niche; add public bookings and screening once core retention is proven.